

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

ADAPTATION NOTES

Online vs. in-person format notes for every activity that changes shape

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Adaptation Notes

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Eight's activities are almost entirely interpersonal, which makes format adaptation more consequential here than in most other stages — a poorly adapted paired exercise doesn't just lose some polish, it can lose the entire point of the practice.

This document covers every activity across Stage Eight's Session Plan and Group Versions of Key Exercises documents that genuinely changes shape between formats. Several notes here address privacy and psychological safety specifically, since this stage's content is more personal than most.

Format Notes by Activity

Activity	In-Person	Online
Paraphrase Relay (FIRST L1)	Pairs turn chairs to face each other directly.	Breakout rooms of 2. Ask Partner B to keep their camera on and genuinely make eye contact with the camera, not the screen, to preserve the real listening dynamic.
Observed Timed Challenge (FIRST L36)	Groups of 3, observer sits slightly outside the pair with a visible tally sheet.	Breakout rooms of 3. Observer keeps their tally in a private chat note or on paper, since a visible on-screen tally could distract the two talking.
Feedback Fishbowl (FIRST L6)	Volunteer sits in a visible center chair; others form a loose circle around them.	Spotlight the volunteer's video tile. Others stay on camera but muted except when giving feedback, so the volunteer can see genuine reactions, not just hear disembodied voices.
Conflict Mediation Role-Play (FIRST L35)	Groups of 3 find a quiet corner or spread around the room for some privacy.	Breakout rooms of 3. This one benefits from genuine privacy — confirm breakout rooms are not being recorded or visibly joined by the facilitator mid-scenario, which can make participants self-conscious.
Silent-Start Brainstorm (FIRST L32)	Individual index cards or sticky notes for the silent phase, shared on a table or wall after.	Use a shared document or virtual whiteboard where everyone types simultaneously during the silent phase, then unmute for the discussion phase.
Team-based exercises (L7, L8, L18, L42, L44, from Session 4)	Small groups cluster around a table, staying together for the full session.	Keep the same breakout room group for the entire session rather than reshuffling — several exercises build on the same team context, and reshuffling breaks that continuity.
Speed Networking Rounds (FIRST L12)	Physical rotation — half the room stands and moves to a new partner each round.	Use the platform's breakout room “re-shuffle” feature to create new random pairs each round automatically, rather than manually reassigning.
Speech Circle with Feedback (FIRST L46)	Small groups, speaker stands while others sit facing them.	Speaker keeps camera on and ideally stands if space allows, even on video — physical posture genuinely affects delivery even through a screen.
Full-group share-outs / closing rounds	Genuine round-robin around the room.	Use “raise hand” or call names directly from a list rather than open-floor, which tends to stall on video.

GENERAL HYBRID GUIDANCE

For a hybrid Session 3 (Feedback & Conflict Resolution), avoid mixing in-person and remote participants within the same role-play or feedback triad — the format asymmetry (one person physically present, one on a screen) makes genuine neutrality and presence harder to sustain. Keep remote participants together in their own breakout groups for this session specifically.

For any exercise involving real emotional content, confirm breakout rooms are genuinely private (not recorded, not silently joined by the facilitator) and say so explicitly — people share more honestly when they trust the privacy of the space.